

INTERVIEW GUIDE FOR RESEARCH STUDY

Re-evaluating the Drivers of Urban Housing Affordability from a Construction Cost Perspective: Evidence from the Emerging Real Estate Market

VOLUNTARY PARTICIPATION STATEMENT

Please read carefully before proceeding:

Your participation in this interview is entirely voluntary. You are under no obligation to answer any questions you do not wish to answer, and you may withdraw from this interview at any time without providing any reason and without any negative consequences. There will be no coercion, pressure, or penalty of any kind for declining to participate or for discontinuing your participation. Your decision to participate or not will not affect your legal rights, employment status, business relationships, or any services you currently receive. By proceeding with this interview, you indicate your voluntary consent to participate.

QUESTIONNAIRE 1: FOR CONSTRUCTION INDUSTRY EXPERTS, REAL ESTATE DEVELOPERS, AND BUILDING MATERIAL RETAILERS/HARDWARE SHOP OPERATORS

Target Stakeholders: Quantity surveyors, architects, engineers (Group 1); Active real estate developers (Group 2); Major hardware shop operators/owners (Group 3)

Estimated Duration: 30-45 minutes

Interviewer Instructions: Read each question exactly as written. Probe only where indicated with [Probe]. Record responses verbatim or use audio recording with participant consent.

Section A: Cost Structures and Pricing Mechanisms

Question 1:

From your professional experience, what are the three most significant cost components that determine the final price or rent of a residential property in Kumasi, and how would you rank them in order of importance?

[Probe: Where does land cost rank compared to construction materials?]

[Probe: Do you calculate your selling prices/rents using a cost-plus formula or based on what similar properties in the area are charging?]

[Probe: Has this pricing approach changed in the last five years? If yes, how?]

For Hardware Retailers only - add this probe: From your perspective as a supplier, how responsive is the demand for building materials to changes in cement and steel prices? Do customers reduce quantities or switch to cheaper alternatives when prices rise?

For Developers only - add this probe: When cement or steel prices increase by 10 percent, what percentage of that increase do you typically pass on to the buyer or tenant? What happens to the remainder?

Question 2:

Can you describe any trade-offs you have observed or personally made between using lower-cost building materials and maintaining construction quality and durability, especially for housing targeting low- or middle-income households?

[Probe: Have you witnessed or been involved in projects where material specifications were reduced to meet budget constraints?]

[Probe: What specific materials are most commonly substituted with cheaper alternatives?]

[Probe: What are the observable consequences of such substitutions (e.g., structural issues, dampness, premature deterioration)?]

[Probe: In your opinion, how does this trade-off affect occupant safety and long-term building maintenance costs?]

For Developers only - add this probe: Do you believe your clients understand when material compromises have been made? How is this communicated, if at all?

For Construction Experts only - add this probe: Have you encountered building failures or regulatory compliance issues linked to sub-standard material use? Can you describe one such instance without revealing identifying information?

Thank you for your time and valuable insights. Your participation contributes to evidence-based housing policy in Ghana.

QUESTIONNAIRE 2: FOR RESIDENTIAL AND COMMERCIAL PROPERTY OCCUPANTS (TENANTS/USERS)

Target Stakeholders: Residential tenants (households); Commercial space users/tenants (shop owners, banking institutions, mobile money vendors)

Estimated Duration: 20-30 minutes

Interviewer Instructions: Read each question exactly as written. Probe only where indicated. For residential respondents, focus on housing. For commercial respondents, focus on business premises.

Section A: Rental/Price Determination Experiences

Question 1:

Thinking about your current rent or the purchase price of this property, what factors did your

landlord, property owner, or seller explicitly mention when justifying the amount you pay or paid?

[Probe: Did they mention the cost of building materials such as cement, steel, or roofing sheets? If yes, how often and with what specific examples?]

[Probe: Did they mention land costs, property location, proximity to markets, schools, or transport?]

[Probe: Were you able to negotiate the amount? If yes, on what basis did you negotiate?]

[Probe: For commercial respondents only: How does your rent compare to similar businesses in different locations within Kumasi?]

For Residential respondents only - add this probe: In your experience, how many times has your rent increased since you moved into this property, and what reasons were given for each increase? Do you recall any increase being specifically attributed to cement price changes?

For Commercial respondents only - add this probe: Does the quality of the building construction (finishes, flooring, security features, aesthetics) directly affect your customers' perception or your business revenue? Would you pay higher rent for a building with superior construction quality?

Question 2:

Have you ever personally experienced or witnessed a situation where a landlord or property owner increased rent or sale price based on rising building material costs, even when no new construction, major renovation, or improvement was made to the property?

[Probe: Can you describe what happened, including when, where, and by approximately what percentage the rent or price increased?]

[Probe: How did you respond to that situation (e.g., paid without question, negotiated, moved out, reported to authorities)?]

[Probe: What is your general belief about the relationship between cement prices and housing rents in Kumasi? Do you believe an increase in cement prices necessarily means rents should increase?]

[Probe: Have you ever considered reporting unfair rent increases to any government agency? If no, why not? If yes, what was the outcome?]

For Residential respondents only - add this probe: Thinking about the quality of construction of your current home (walls, roof, floors, plumbing, ventilation), do you believe the property was built using standard, high-quality materials or were corners cut to reduce costs? What specific signs lead you to this conclusion?

For Commercial respondents only - add this probe: If construction material prices were stabilised by government policy tomorrow, do you believe your landlord would reduce your rent? Why or why not?

Thank you for your time and honest responses. Your experiences are invaluable for understanding the real drivers of housing affordability in Kumasi.

INTERVIEWER CLOSING PROTOCOL (For both questionnaires)

After completing the interview, please:

1. Thank the participant again for their voluntary participation
2. Reassure them that their responses will be anonymised and used only for research purposes
3. Offer to share summary findings if they provided contact information (optional)
4. Ask if they have any questions about the research
5. Confirm that their participation is complete and no further contact will occur without consent
6. Record any notable non-verbal observations or contextual notes immediately after the participant departs

Confidentiality Note: Store all signed consent forms separately from interview data. Assign each participant a unique code. Do not record names or specific property addresses on this questionnaire.

End of Interview Guide